THE VANGUARD

ASSAM RIFLES—EARLY HISTORY

Most writers who have commented on the events leading up to the conflict between India and China in October-November 1962 have failed to pay adequate attention to the crucial role played by the Assam Rifles. Quite naturally, the entire focus was on the Indian Army and its failure to stop the Chinese assault when it came. Some observers, including the journalist Neville Maxwell, as well as declassified CIA reports, have zeroed in on Nehru's Forward Policy and tried to lay the blame at India's doorstep. This is a blatantly unfair charge, for the Forward Policy as a whole needs to be understood in its entirety, as it had been in existence from around the early 1900s. The Assam Rifles pushing forward into NEFA was a continuation of British consolidation tactics that had been put into place since 1878. Once the McMahon Line had been drawn and the Himalayan watershed identified as the boundary, it was but natural for the Assam Rifles, the only real arm of the government in the region, to make their presence felt. The army would only come into play much later. However, to get a better understanding of this police force that would play a major role in the events leading up to 1962, one must first dwell briefly on its history.

Infighting among the Ahom rulers of Assam opened the door to the British. In 1792, while the Nepalese were fighting the Tibetans, the events taking place in Assam would influence the course of history for the next 150 years. At the height of the Moamoria Rebellion (1769-1806), the Ahom king, Gaurinath Singha, turned to the rising power in the subcontinent, the British, and appealed for help. At that time the East India Company held sway over most parts of the country with only two major Indian powers hostile to the British still holding out—Tipu Sultan in Srirangapatna (Mysore) and the Marathas. In the east, Bengal had fallen into British clutches after the Battle of Plassey (1757) and the Company at the time